Letsema in partnership with Skift Advisory, for Wesgro

Unlocking Tourism Growth

A Strategy for the Western Cape to 2035

Final Research Report

Draft for discussion, version 1, November 2026

DRAFT FOR DISCUSSION. Not for circulation beyond the Wesgro project team.

Document control

Item	Detail
Title	Unlocking Tourism Growth: A Strategy for the Western Cape to 2035. Final Research Report
Client	Wesgro, the Western Cape Tourism, Trade and Investment Promotion Agency
Authors	Letsema Consulting and Advisory in partnership with Skift Advisory
Contract	Service Level Agreement, Annexure B, clause 1.1.14 (Final Research Report); clauses 1.1.4 and 1.1.10 (M&E toolkit)
Status	Draft for discussion, version 1. Every page carries the draft marking until the Steerco review
Audience	Unlocking Tourism Steerco, Wesgro Exco and Board; the written report launches at the Unlocking Tourism business outlook, February 2027
Conventions	Figures carry a source and page in the form (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21). Square-bracketed text marks an open item. See section 1.5

Foreword

[Foreword by the Chief Executive Officer of Wesgro, one page. To be drafted by Wesgro or ghost-written by Letsema for sign-off, SLA Annexure B clause 1.1.14.5.]

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Abbreviations

Abbreviation	Meaning
ACSA	Airports Company South Africa
CAGR	Compound annual growth rate
CTAA	Cape Town Air Access
CTIA	Cape Town International Airport
CTICC	Cape Town International Convention Centre
CTT	Cape Town Tourism
DEDAT	Department of Economic Development and Tourism, Western Cape Government
DMO	Destination marketing organisation
FTE	Full-time equivalent
FY	Financial year (April to March)
G4J	Growth for Jobs Strategy, Western Cape Government, 2023
GCC	Gulf Cooperation Council
GDPR	Gross domestic product by region
GVA	Gross value added
ICCA	International Congress and Convention Association
LTO	Local tourism organisation
M&E	Monitoring and evaluation
Mero	Municipal Economic Review and Outlook
MICE	Meetings, incentives, conferences and exhibitions
OAG	Official Airline Guide (schedules and capacity data)
OSM	OpenStreetMap
OTA	Online travel agency
Pero	Provincial Economic Review and Outlook
RACI	Responsible, accountable, consulted, informed
SAT	South African Tourism
SLA	Service level agreement
SMME	Small, medium and micro enterprise
Stats SA	Statistics South Africa
TSA	Tourism Satellite Account
UIA	Union of International Associations
VFR	Visiting friends and relatives
WTTC	World Travel and Tourism Council

Executive summary

This file is a work-in-progress build of the final report, packaged on 3 November 2026 for review of the structure, the build and the first drafted section.

What this build contains and what it does not

Contains. The front matter (cover, document control, foreword placeholder, contents, lists of figures and tables, abbreviations) and section 1.2, The Western Cape tourism system today, drafted from the verified evidence extracts with three figures and three tables. Section 1.2 has not yet passed its adversarial review; a reviewer is checking every figure against the source pages.

Does not yet contain. Sections 1.1, 1.3, 1.4 and 1.5 (drafting in progress); Chapter 2 (six analysis summaries, next); Chapter 3 (20 focus-area entries, after Chapter 2); Chapters 4 and 5; the appendices; the executive summary, which is written last from the Chapter 3 toplines.

Evidence base behind it. Twelve deliverables and memos read in full and adversarially verified, figure by figure; a reconciliation log of 55 discrepancies between the structure document, the brief and the deliverables (discrepancies.md); a reconstruction of the hypothesis tree with dispositions (evidence/tree.md); fact sheets for five of the six themes, with the sixth and the audits in progress.

Conventions already in force. Every figure carries a source and page in the form (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21); page numbers are PDF page indices because the decks print none; square brackets mark open items; every page carries the draft marking; figures are redrawn from the extracted data rather than pasted.

Context

1.1 Mandate and objective

Wesgro commissioned a strategy to "double international tourist arrivals to the Western Cape by 2035"; the evidence has reframed that ambition as growth to 2.5 million arrivals, set by supply rather than demand.

Wesgro's mandate

Wesgro's mandate frames this strategy. The agency promotes tourism, trade and investment for Cape Town and the Western Cape, and the tourism goal sits inside that wider economic brief. Its mission is to work "together with partners, drive inclusive and sustainable economic growth, strengthen competitiveness, and create jobs in Cape Town and the Western Cape" (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p5).

Its vision is to "be a leading regional tourism, trade and investment promotion agency" (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p5). Two points in the mission matter for what follows: growth is a means to jobs, and Wesgro acts through partners rather than holding the levers itself.

Wesgro's strategy runs to eight statements, quoted here as printed (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p5):

- "Ensure that Cape Town and the Western Cape is top of mind as a leading business and tourism destination with premium products and services."
- "Prioritise new investment into identified export priority areas."
- "Increase re-investment and expansion from existing WC businesses."
- "Unlock access to new markets and new buyers - China, ASEAN, India, Brazil & Middle East, while maintaining a continued focus on established markets."
- "Enhance and replicate catalytic delivery models to deliver economic impact with partners in key areas."
- "Track and address systemic challenges influencing economic competitiveness."
- "Provide economic data, insights & analytics for the Western Cape."
- "Digitally transform across all our mandates to place clients at the centre of how we deliver services, enable staff and to empower stakeholders."

Four of the eight bear directly on this study. The first sets the destination proposition and the fourth names the new buyer markets while holding the established ones. The sixth commits Wesgro to act on systemic constraints to competitiveness and the seventh makes it the province's source of economic data.

The study objective and the original ambitions

The study objective was set in November 2025. It reads in full: "To develop an evidence-based tourism strategy that will double international tourist arrivals to the Western Cape by 2035, through a holistic approach that drives demand, strengthens supply and enables inclusive, sustainable and geographically dispersed growth aligned with WESGRO's strategic priorities" (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4). That sentence fixes the three pillars the report keeps throughout: demand, supply and enablement.

Four headline ambitions sat under the objective: 2.8 million international visitors, 300,000 tourism-linked jobs, 10,000 SMMEs onboarded and twice the airlift and cruise volumes (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4). None carried a base year, a baseline value or a definition; the only year on the slide is 2035. A month later the Current State Diagnostic restated the ambition as 5.7 million arrivals and R54.7 billion in tourism spend by 2035, again without a base (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5).

The two statements do not reconcile with each other or with the measured baseline. Cape Town International recorded 1.44 million international passenger arrivals in FY24/25 (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Twice that is 2.88 million, close to the 2.8 million ambition and nowhere near 5.7 million, and neither ambition names the series it counts.

The demand model tested the ambition and reframed it. From a 2025 base of 1,498,829 international arrivals, the base case reaches 2,175,778 by 2035 and the accelerated case 2,516,282, with a conservative floor of 1,822,634 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19). The accelerated case is what this strategy calls growth to 2.5 million, and it is the goal the report carries.

The reframing rests on what the model says about access: the base case assumes Wesgro's effort at 2025 intensity, selective frequency gains on existing routes and continued hub expansion (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p18). The accelerated case adds confirmed direct routes to India and China, above-baseline activation and more hub capacity into Cape Town (p18). The model's own footnote is blunt: without confirmed routes, volume reverts to base (p19).

Even the base case runs into a ceiling. Current air access caps inbound capacity at 1.8 million seats, and the base case first passes that line at the 2030 plotted year, at 1,802,929 arrivals (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20). Growth to 2.5 million is therefore a supply programme before it is a marketing programme, and every chapter of this report returns to that point.

The reframing was tabled with Wesgro at the summary-of-findings session of 14 October 2026 [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, page to be confirmed against the final deck]. The table below sets each original ambition against the baseline in hand and the form in which the strategy now carries it.

Table 1.1. The study reframed the arrivals ambition on evidence and carried the other three ambitions forward with their baselines still to be fixed.

Ambition (November 2025)	Baseline in hand	How the strategy carries it
2.8 million international visitors by 2035	1.44m international passenger arrivals at Cape Town International, FY24/25 (Diagnostic p25); model base 1,498,829 in 2025 (Market Assessment p19)	Growth to 2.5 million: accelerated case 2,516,282 and base case 2,175,778 by 2035 (Market Assessment p19). The Diagnostic's 5.7 million arrivals and R54.7 billion spend (p5) is recorded as superseded
300,000 tourism-linked jobs	No Western Cape tourism employment figure in any deliverable	Carried to Chapter 5 as a ratio-based projection, pending the labour analysis the strategy commissions under workforce and service skills (focus area 20, flagged)
10,000 SMMEs onboarded	No baseline or definition printed [Wesgro to confirm the baseline count and definition of SMMEs onboarded]	Carried as community inclusion, measured in visitor spend reaching priority communities rather than a count of firms; see 2.6 and Chapter 5
Twice the airlift and cruise volumes	Airlift: inbound capacity capped at 1.8 million seats (Market Assessment p20). Cruise: 79 vessels in the 2024/25 season (Diagnostic p37)	Airlift carried as the seats and routes needed to lift the 1.8 million ceiling (3.2.1). Cruise carried as calls and ports (3.2.1) [Cruise Cape Town to confirm the call target and its definition]

Source: Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4; Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5, p25, p37; Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19, p20.

Wesgro's outcome metrics

Wesgro measures itself against six strategic outcomes, each with one metric (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p6). The slide prints no period for any of them [Wesgro to confirm the period over which the six outcome metrics are measured]. The six are:

- A differentiated Cape Town and the Western Cape as a leading regional economy: 120 million audience reached to consider Cape Town and the Western Cape as a leading trade and tourism destination
- Increased foreign and domestic investment: R30 billion new investment with a focus on targeted areas and markets
- Growth in Western Cape exports of goods and services: R9.1 billion new export declarations for goods and services
- Growth in leisure tourism consideration in international and local markets: 800,000 to 1 million new international tourist arrivals
- Growth in business events hosted in the Western Cape: 161 business event bids secured with an estimated economic value of R4.5 billion
- A future-fit and trusted Wesgro: clean audit, satisfied clients and low culture entropy

Two of the six are tourism metrics, and the period decides how they compare with the growth case. The base case adds 676,949 arrivals between 2025 and 2035 and the accelerated case 1,017,453 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19), so 800,000 to 1 million new arrivals sits between the two paths over a ten-year horizon. Over a horizon to 2030 it sits well above the base case, which adds about 304,000 by then (1,802,929 against 1,498,829; p20).

The business-events metric ties to the green-season case. International association meetings in Cape Town rose from 33 in 2022 to 58 in 2024 and cluster between May and November (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p26), the half of the year in which demand is weakest (p25). Chapter 5 fixes the period for both metrics and sets them against the growth case on one basis.

Alignment with provincial strategy

The SLA requires this report to align with the Growth for Jobs Strategy and with Wesgro's five-year plan (SLA Annexure B, clause 1.1.14.2). The inception report carries the same instruction: recommendations are to align with both the G4J strategy and Wesgro's FY26 to FY30 plan (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p22). The report is the Final Research Report under clause 1.1.14. Chapter 5 answers the monitoring and evaluation clauses 1.1.4 and 1.1.10 [clause references to be checked against the signed SLA Annexure B, whose wording is not in hand].

The Growth for Jobs Strategy 2023, approved by Cabinet, was among the first documents Wesgro supplied to the study (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p34). It designates tourism a primary tradable sector for the province (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5). Its arrivals target is 3 million international tourist arrivals by 2035 on the South African Tourism basis, built as 2 million in 2019 plus 1 million (Wesgro, presentation to the Standing Committee, 1 Apr 2026; public source). [G4J 2023 document to be read and the 3 million target confirmed against it.]

The G4J figure and the study's figures count different things. Three million is provincial tourist arrivals as South African Tourism measures them; 1.44 million is passenger arrivals through one airport as ACSA counts them. On the SAT basis the province received about 1.5 million international tourist arrivals in 2025 (Provincial Minister's statement, reported April 2026; public source) [Wesgro Research to confirm the 2025 SAT figure and the series behind it]. The strategy's 2.5 million therefore cannot be set against the 3 million without conversion.

Wesgro's FY26 to FY30 plan is the second alignment test. A Wesgro five-year strategy was supplied to the study (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p34), but no plan document is in hand. Alignment is therefore stated at the level the inception report gives it [Wesgro to supply the FY26 to FY30 plan and its tourism targets, so that the Chapter 5 baselines and the Chapter 4 phase gates can be mapped to the plan cycle]. Chapter 4 sets its first decision gate at the end of 2028, within the plan period and before the base case reaches the seat ceiling.

One set of arrivals bases

Eight arrivals figures circulate around this strategy and they count four different things. The table below fixes each one and states how the report uses it, so that no later chapter mixes an airport count with a provincial tourist count or an ambition with a projection. Cape Town International is where international visitors enter the province and disperse from, and the Diagnostic itself uses Cape Town air arrivals as the proxy for provincial performance (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p26, p41).

Table 1.2. The report uses airport passenger arrivals for baselines, the demand model for targets and South African Tourism's provincial count only to read across to the Growth for Jobs target.

Figure	What it counts	Year	Source	How this report uses it
1.44m	International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International (ACSA), fiscal year	FY24/25	Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25	Recovery baseline (1.2) and the baseline year for the M&E framework (Chapter 5)
1.57m	Same series	FY25/26	Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p10	Latest actual; shown against the model, not substituted for its base
1,498,829	Demand model base; the series and year basis are not labelled in the deck	2025	Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19	Base of the growth case; every 2035 figure in Chapters 3 to 5 is an increment on it
2,175,778 and 2,516,282	Model projections on the 2025 base: base case and accelerated case	2035	Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19	The strategy's two paths; growth to 2.5 million is the rounded accelerated case
About 1.5m	International tourist arrivals to the Western Cape, South African Tourism basis	2025	Provincial Minister's statement, reported April 2026 (public source)	Reference point for the G4J basis only; not a baseline or a target [Wesgro Research to confirm]
3 million	International tourist arrivals to the province, SAT basis, built as 2 million in 2019 plus 1 million	2035	Wesgro, presentation to the Standing Committee, 1 Apr 2026 (public source), recording the G4J 2023 target	Alignment reference under clause 1.1.14.2; a different measure from the airport series
2.8m	"International visitors"; measure and base not stated	2035	Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4	Original ambition; quoted, not used

Figure	What it counts	Year	Source	How this report uses it
5.7 million and R54.7 billion	International arrivals and tourism spend; base not stated	2035	Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5	The Diagnostic's statement of the ambition; superseded and quoted for the record

Source: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p5, p25; Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p10, p19; Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4; Wesgro, presentation to the Standing Committee, 1 Apr 2026 (public source); Provincial Minister's statement, reported April 2026 (public source).

Three rules follow. Airport passenger arrivals at Cape Town International, by fiscal year, are the baseline and tracking series, with FY24/25 at 1.44 million anchoring 1.2 and the Chapter 5 baseline year. The demand model's 2025 base and its 2035 points are the target series, and South African Tourism's provincial count is used once, to read across to the G4J target.

One caution closes the section: the FY25/26 actual of 1.57 million already sits above the model's 2025 base and below its 2028 base-case point of 1,673,855 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p10, p20). The two series differ in measure and period, so the gap is not evidence that the model is cautious. The report quotes them side by side and never adds one to the other [model owner to confirm the series and year basis behind the 2025 base of 1,498,829].

1.2 The Western Cape tourism system today

The Western Cape's international tourism has recovered to a record, and the system that delivered the recovery runs through five source markets, six summer months and one metro.

Arrivals and recovery

International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International reached 1.44m in FY24/25, against 1.16m in FY19/20, the last pre-pandemic year (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Arrivals passed the pre-pandemic peak of 1.19m, set in FY18/19, during FY23/24, when they reached 1.36m (p25). FY25/26 added a further step to 1.57m (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11).

The fall and the climb were both steep. Arrivals dropped to 80,400 in FY20/21 and 378,500 in FY21/22, then returned to 1.07m in FY22/23 (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Two-way international passengers reached 2.90m in FY24/25, 29% above FY17/18 (p35), and 3.3m in calendar 2025 inside a total of 11.1m, both up 7% on the year (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p22).

Cape Town's recovery also ran ahead of the national one, so the destination gained share as it recovered. In the first half of 2024 its air arrivals had recovered further against 2019 than South Africa's in eight of the ten largest markets (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p26). The USA stood at 162% and Australia at 172% of their 2019 level (p26).

Three arrivals measures

The 1.44m is ACSA's count of international passengers arriving at Cape Town International in the fiscal year. It is the series this report uses as its recovery baseline and its monitoring base year (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25).

South African Tourism counts tourist arrivals to the province, which the Demand-Side Analysis notes are distinct from airport passenger traffic (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p27). The growth model in Chapter 2 runs from a third series, a 2025 base of 1,498,829 international arrivals (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19).

The deliverables do not reconcile the three, so the report names the measure each time it cites an arrivals figure.

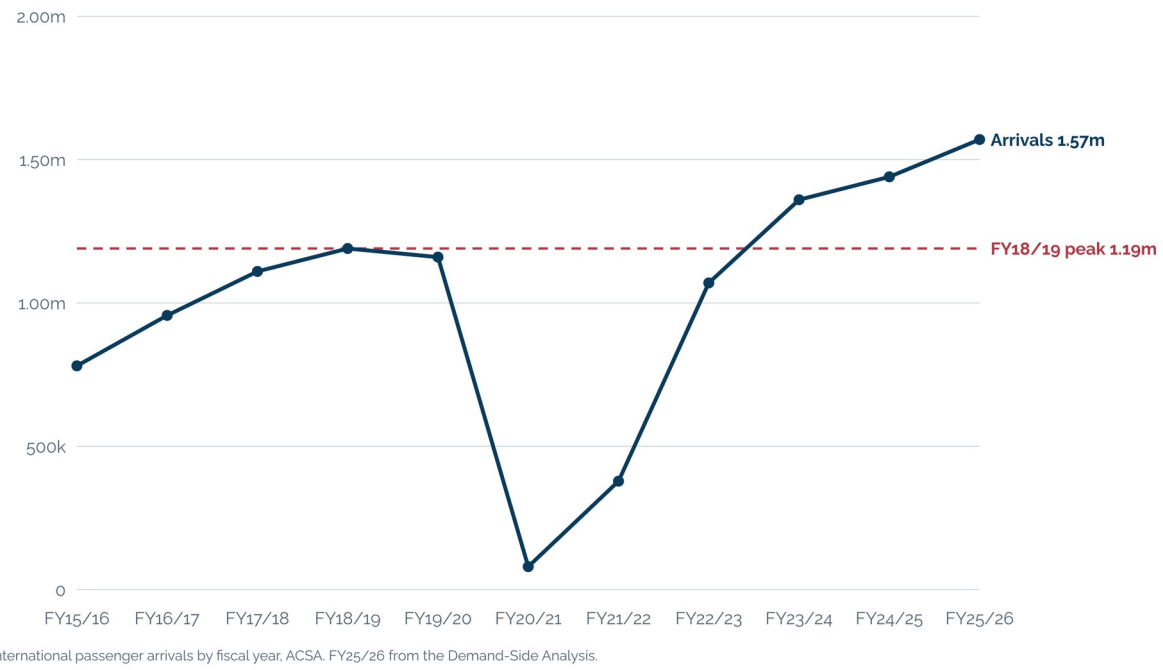


Figure 1.1. International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International passed their pre-pandemic peak in FY23/24 and reached 1.44m in FY24/25 and 1.57m in FY25/26.

Source: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25 (FY15/16 to FY24/25); Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11 (FY25/26). CTIA and ACSA CPT passenger statistics, international arrivals by fiscal year.

Spend and value

Foreign direct spend in the province rose from R22.7bn in FY2024 to R25.9bn in FY2025, a gain of 14% in one year (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11). The Western Cape earns that spend from a modest share of the national market. Across the four quarters of 2025 it took 16%, 13%, 13% and 16% of South Africa's foreign arrivals and 26%, 20%, 22% and 27% of foreign direct spend (p11).

The gap between the two shares is the province's premium. About a quarter of national spend from about a seventh of arrivals means the average foreign visitor to the Western Cape spends roughly 1.6 times the national average (computed from p11). The province earns about US$890 per international arrival, against US$500 for the rest of South Africa and US$630 for Morocco, though below Kenya's US$1,460 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p15).

More than a quarter of overseas visitors stay between 7 and 21 days, on printed bands that sum to only 48% (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12). Some 5% stay 1 to 2 days, 12% 3 to 4, 14% 7 to 10, 3% 11 to 14, 13% 15

to 21 and 1% other (p12). The Diagnostic prints the same distribution from the 2024 Wesgro Visitor Tracking Survey, in which 52.33% of respondents gave no length of stay, so the bands describe about half the sample (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25).

The modal visitor in the 2024 Wesgro survey spends R1,000 to R2,000 a day, is aged 36 to 50 and travels as a pair (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). Nearly 40% spend more than R1,000 a day (p27). Self-catering at 17.4% and guesthouses at 9.7% lead accommodation choice, ahead of hotels at 3.6% (p27).

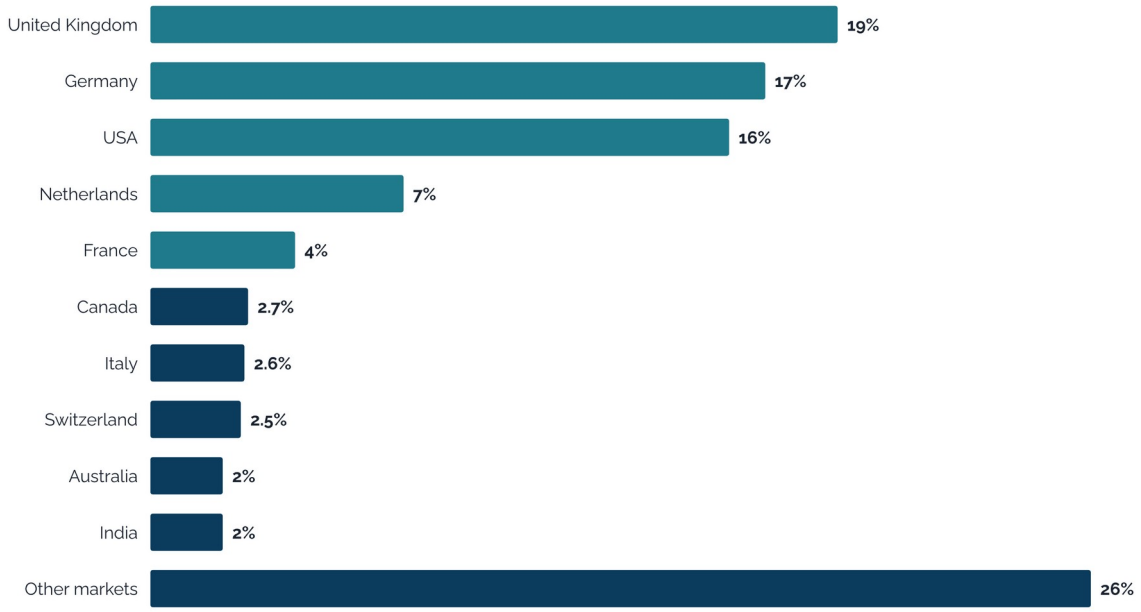
Source markets

Five markets supply 63% of overseas arrivals. In 2025 the UK held 19%, Germany 17%, the USA 16%, the Netherlands 7% and France 4%, and the three largest alone held 52% (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13). The same slide prints 61% in its text; the report uses 63%, the sum of the printed shares, and logs the conflict.

Concentration is not new. On the Cape Town overseas air-arrivals basis for January to August 2024 the same five markets held 61%, with the UK and the USA at 18% each and Germany at 15% (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p29). The growth markets remain small: India supplied about 2.6% of South Africa's overseas tourists in September 2025, the Middle East 2.3% and China 1.4% (p30).

The mature markets also pay the most. Average spend per visitor in 2024 ran from R32,900 for the USA, R26,500 for the UK and R25,600 for Germany down to R8,600 for Namibia and R8,500 for Zimbabwe (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p14). The spread is 3.9 times, and the two regional markets compensate with stability, repeat demand and counter-seasonal volume (p14).

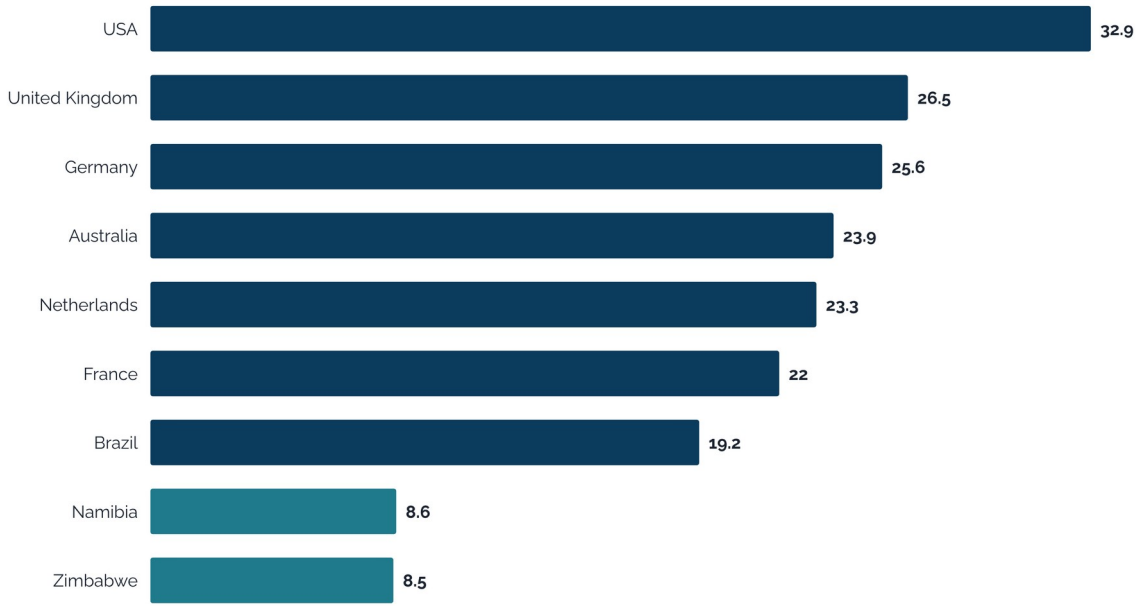
Most of these visitors arrive through someone else's hub. The UAE route carried 222,923 air arrivals into Cape Town in 2025, the UK 158,448, Qatar 126,078, Ethiopia 123,250 and Turkiye 89,090 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13). The four hub routes through Dubai, Doha, Addis Ababa and Istanbul carried 53% of arrivals on the ten largest routes (computed from p13), so the hubs, not the source markets, are the province's working gateways.



Share of overseas arrivals to the Western Cape, 2025. The five highlighted markets sum to 63%.

Figure 1.2. Five markets supplied 63% of overseas arrivals in 2025, and the UK, Germany and the USA alone supplied 52%.

Source: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13 (Stats SA and SAT International Performance Report 2025). The same slide prints 61% in its text; the five shares shown sum to 63%.



Average spend per visitor, R thousand, 2024. Regional markets highlighted.

Figure 1.3. Average spend per visitor in 2024 ranged from R32,900 for the USA to R8,500 for Zimbabwe, a spread of 3.9 times.

Source: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p14 (Stats SA and SAT International Performance Report). Average spend in the Western Cape by source market, ZAR, 2024.

Seasonality

Demand peaks in the southern summer. In 2025, 12.7% of overseas visitors travelled in December, 11.5% in January and 11.3% in November, against 6.1% in June and 6.5% in August (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12). October to March together account for about 65% of the year.

That 65% is derived, not printed. The twelve monthly shares on the 2025 slide sum to 104.9%, so the October to March figure is provisional and flagged wherever it appears [Wesgro Research to confirm the 2025 month-of-travel shares]. The 2024 Wesgro Visitor Tracking Survey, whose monthly shares sum to 100%, gives 61% for October to March and 39% for April to September (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25, p32).

Supply follows the same curve. June carries 6.4% of 2025 international seat capacity into Cape Town (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"), and Cape Town hotel occupancy was 53% in June 2023 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p34). The Diagnostic drew the conclusion early: growth "will depend on improving conversion in Apr-Sep rather than pushing incremental demand into already busy peak months" (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p32).

Table 1.3. Six summer months, October to March, carry between 61% and 65% of overseas visitors' travel in the two years for which month of travel is recorded.

Year	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec	Oct to Mar
2024	9%	13%	12%	8%	7%	4%	6%	7%	7%	10%	10%	7%	61%
2025 (provisional)	11.5%	9.9%	10.3 %	6.9%	6.8%	6.1%	6.7%	6.5%	7.0%	9.2%	11.3%	12.7%	65%

Source: 2024: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25 and p32 (Wesgro Visitor Tracking Survey 2024; shares sum to 100%). 2025: Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p12 (Stats SA and SAT 2025; the printed shares sum to 104.9%, so the 2025 row and its October to March share are provisional).

Air and sea access

Ten airlines fly to Cape Town International from Africa, nine from Europe, three from North and South America, two from the Middle East and one from Asia (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p35). The aviation assessment states the gap plainly as "the absence of any direct capacity to any of the Asian markets", India and China included (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The Capetown Market"). Twenty-nine international routes serve the airport in 2026 (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Executive Summary").

Cape Town International itself is now the physical ceiling. One runway with no parallel taxiway caps movements at about 30 an hour, and ACSA's programme of about R11.3bn brings relief only from about 2032 to 2034 (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p101 to p103). The secondary gateways do not change the picture: George, above its design limit at 911,000 passengers in 2025, doubles by 2028 (p104, p105), and Cape Winelands Airport targets 2028 with no named carrier (p106, p107).

Cruise has grown without new berth capacity. The province hosted 70, 67 and 79 vessels in the 2022/23, 2023/24 and 2024/25 seasons, carrying 144,125, 109,884 and 127,178 passengers (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p37). The Infrastructure Report counts 83 calls at the Cape Town berth in 2024/25, 127,000 passengers and R1.79bn of economic impact (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p110). [StratEcon 2024/25 cruise report to confirm whether 79 vessels and 83 calls differ by definition.]

Port reliability, not berth space, is the risk. The single berth ran at about 40% of a season capacity of 150 or more calls, and its limits are a 300m ship length and the South-Easter wind (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p110). The Diagnostic calls the Port of Cape Town "a binding constraint, with congestion and equipment failures affecting export and cruise reliability" (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p34).

Geography of the system

The Cape Metro generates 72.5% of provincial GDPR, a whole-economy share rather than a tourism one (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p39; Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p22). The Cape Winelands follows at 11.2%, the Garden Route at 7.6%, the West Coast at 4.8%, the Overberg at 3% and the Central Karoo at 0.5% (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p42 to p50). The decks date only the Garden Route share, to 2023, while the Metro chart is titled 2024 and the rest carry no year (p39, p42).

Tourism supply is concentrated in the same way. The Infrastructure Report mapped 50,332 tourism assets across the six regions, of which the Metro holds 20,281, or 40.3% (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p2, p23). The Garden Route holds 9,875, the Cape Winelands 7,730, the Overberg 6,176, the West Coast 4,752 and the Central Karoo 1,518 (p34, p45, p56, p67, p78).

Cape Town is the axle of the system, "the province's global shopfront and primary dispersal hub" in the Infrastructure Report's words (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p22). The Diagnostic warns that "any capacity failure in Cape Town quickly becomes a provincial risk, not just a city problem" (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p41). International visitors land there and disperse from there, and readiness falls with each step away: accessibility scores drop from 4.7 in the Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90).

Beyond the Metro the visitor drives. The N2 is "the only continuous inter-regional tourism corridor, creating a single point of failure", and large parts of the province outside the Metro and the Garden Route remain effectively car-only destinations (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p98, p99). The further from Cape Town, the faster the infrastructure falls away (p90).

Table 1.4. The Cape Metro holds 72.5% of provincial GDPR and 40% of the province's tourism assets, and accessibility falls with each step away from it.

District	Share of provincial GDPR	Tourism assets	Share of assets	Accessibility score (1 to 5)
Cape Metro	72.5%	20,281	40.3%	4.7
Cape Winelands	11.2%	7,730	15.4%	3.3
Garden Route	7.6%	9,875	19.6%	3.0
West Coast	4.8%	4,752	9.4%	1.7
Overberg	3%	6,176	12.3%	2.0
Central Karoo	0.5%	1,518	3.0%	1.0
Western Cape		50,332	100%	

Source: GDPR shares: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p39, p42, p44, p46, p48, p50 (year not printed; Garden Route share is for 2023). Asset counts: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p2, p23, p34, p45, p56, p67, p78 (the Winelands gauge misprints 40.3%; 7,730 of 50,332 is 15.4%). Accessibility: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90, attractions and services basis; the Metro scores 5.0 on transport.

Rail, roads and utilities

Passenger rail has collapsed as a mode. Trainsets fell from about 110 in 1995 to about 91, pushing some 400,000 commuters onto saturated roads, and congestion in the Metro costs an estimated R2.8bn a year (Current State

Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p38). Metrorail still runs 460km, five lines and 104 of 121 stations, with 22.7m passenger trips in FY2025, but no line reaches the airport and it is rated functionally unusable for tourism (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p100, p90).

Utilities cap the periphery before demand does. Water scarcity in high-growth nodes such as the Garden Route acts as a "hard ceiling" for visitor load, and load shedding raises costs and degrades the experience in peripheral districts (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p38). The airport has no fuel pipeline and depends on road tankers (p38), and the 2017 to 2018 water crisis left a lasting perception of resource pressure (p55).

The remedies are named but not scheduled. The Diagnostic lists four transport enablers, none dated or costed: the Cape Town Integrator, rail restoration and devolution, a high-speed city to airport link and George to Cape Winelands passenger rail (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p38). PRASA's R21.1bn programme and the City's R123bn, 30-year devolution case cover fleet and lines, and neither carries a tourism product or an airport link (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p100).

Institutions

Wesgro runs the demand side of this system through six units: Cape Town Air Access, Cruise Cape Town, the Convention Bureau, Destination Marketing, Research and Tourism (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p7). Around them sit fifteen external organisations, from national agencies and state-owned entities to the province, the City, destination and attraction bodies and private operators (p7). The table below sets out who holds what.

The levers that bind the system sit at different tiers. National government holds visa rules, border compliance, air service agreements and route rights (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58). The province holds jobs, inclusion and spatial outcomes, sector development and infrastructure planning; local government holds service delivery, precinct management and events readiness; industry holds route viability, demand generation and product standards (p58).

Alignment across those tiers is thin. The Diagnostic records specific dysfunctions, "SAT is in turmoil" among them, and the added pressure of a lack of fiscal space (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58). More than twenty bodies produce tourism data and "there is no single view of visitor behaviour, making strategy reactive rather than predictive" (p57).

Stakeholders say the same. Fifteen of the sixteen organisations interviewed raised industry and government collaboration (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p20 to p46; the count is of organisations with at least one insight under the theme). The Department of Economic Development named restrictive bilateral air agreements and destination funding materially below peer destinations as high-impact constraints (p24, p25).

Table 1.5. Wesgro's six units sit inside a system of fifteen external organisations whose decision rights are split across three spheres of government and industry.

Group	Organisations	What sits here
Wesgro units	Cape Town Air Access; Cruise Cape Town; Convention Bureau; Destination Marketing; Research; Tourism	Route development, cruise, business events bids, destination marketing, research and tourism promotion for Cape Town and the Western Cape

Group	Organisations	What sits here
Provincial and city government	Western Cape Government (Economic Development and Tourism); City of Cape Town	Provincial tier: jobs, inclusion and spatial outcomes; sector development and safety programmes; infrastructure planning and resilience. Local tier: service delivery and precinct management; events readiness and place experience; congestion, by-laws and community impact
National agencies and state-owned entities	South African Tourism; Airports Company South Africa; Transnet; South African Maritime Safety Authority	National tier: visa rules and border compliance; air service agreements and route rights; national brand and investment priorities. Airport capacity and port operations
Destination and attraction bodies	Cape Town Tourism; V&A Waterfront; CapeNature; South African National Parks; Table Mountain Aerial Cableway	Industry tier: demand generation and destination marketing; product quality and visitor experience at the flagship sites
Private operators	MSC Cruises; Cape Grace; Pullman Hotels and Resorts (Cape Town City Centre); Southern Sun	Industry tier: route and product viability and commercial performance; pricing and service standards

Source: Inception Report, Nov 2025, p7 (organisations as shown on the stakeholder map; the grouping is this report's); Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58 (functions by tier).

None of these constraints is a shortage of visitors. The runway, the single corridor, a rail network visitors cannot use, the thin winter schedule and decision rights split across three tiers all sit outside a marketing budget. The system has recovered; its constraints are now physical and institutional.

1.3 From recovery to growth

The recovery is complete, and the growth that follows is capped by supply rather than demand.

The limits of recovery logic

The study set out in December 2025 to move the destination from recovery to growth; the hypothesis tree's own framing reads that "the Western Cape must transition from recovery to growth" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p62). The first half of that task is done. International passenger arrivals at Cape Town International reached 1.44m in FY24/25 against 1.16m in FY19/20, and 1.57m in FY25/26 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11).

Recovery logic assumed capacity waiting to be refilled. Arrivals fell to 80,400 in FY20/21 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p11), and the task was to refill idle seats, rooms and routes. That slack is gone. South Africa's international seat capacity is back at pre-pandemic levels, and Cape Town International runs the highest average load factor of the country's five largest airports, 79% in 2025 (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "The South African Market").

Cape Town did more than refill its seats. It added 17 mainline international routes between 2015 and 2025, more than any of eight peer airports, and MIDAS calls the result "a 'what next' moment" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "International Comparisons"; "In Conclusion"). The rebound that a recovery plan is built to capture has already happened.

Demand without seats

Growth is now supply-constrained, not demand-constrained. Skift's survey of 34 outbound markets counts 97 million high-value, South Africa-interested travellers, of whom only 1.4 million convert into arrivals (Market

Assessment Report, May 2026, p41). The report's conclusion is that "the challenge is not demand generation but improving conversion into actual visits" (p41).

The binding supply is seats. Current air access places a hard ceiling at 1.8 million inbound seats, and the base case, in which Wesgro maintains current activity, reaches 1,802,929 arrivals at the 2030 plotted year (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20). The chart below sets the base case against that ceiling.

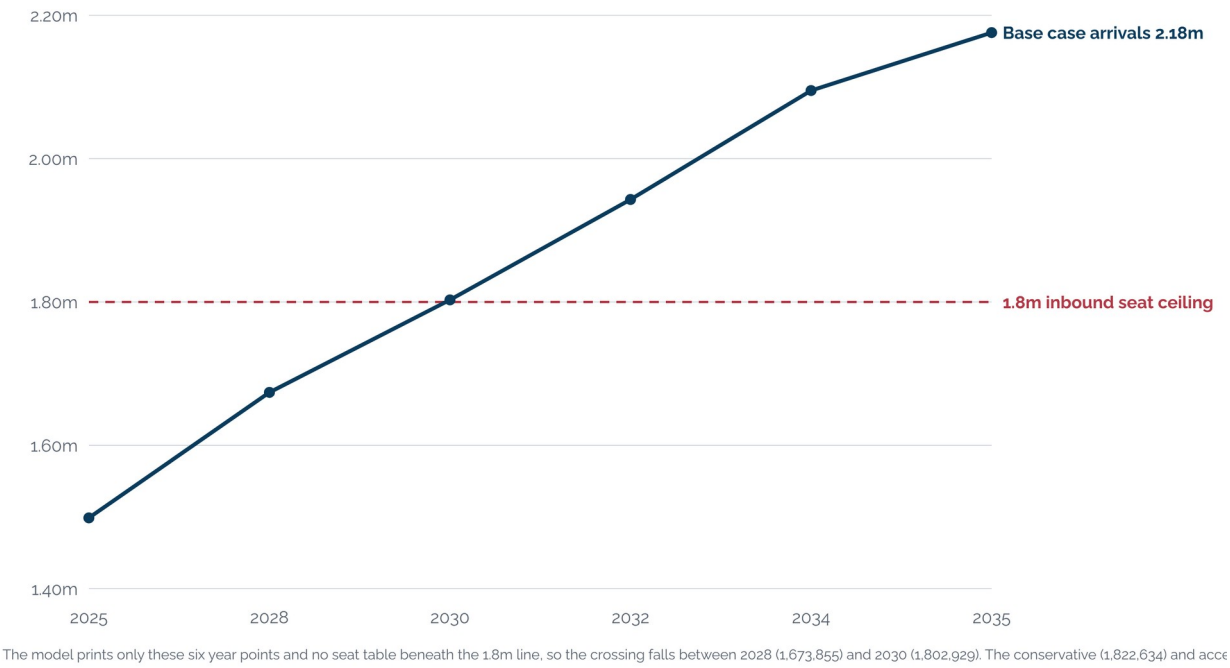


Figure 1.4. The base case crosses the 1.8m inbound seat ceiling at the 2030 plotted year, two years before the earliest relief at Cape Town International.

Source: Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p20 (base case by year from a 2025 base of 1,498,829; the 2028 to 2035 points are identical in the Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21). Seat ceiling as drawn on the same slide. Airport relief from about 2032: Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p103.

The routes that exist are full. Eleven of the 27 international routes in the load-factor table ran above 80% in the year to November 2025, and the network averaged 76.0% on the printed total (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "Seasonality"). Five of the eleven are mature long-haul routes, led by Newark at 88.6%, Atlanta at 84.3% and Frankfurt and London Heathrow at 83.0% ("Seasonality").

Full routes do not add seats of their own accord. MIDAS expects that "rather than increase capacity carriers will seek to increase revenues via higher selling fares rather than add new services" (MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment, Mar 2026, "In Conclusion"). Airlines also pull seats out of winter: June carries 6.4% of the year's international capacity and December 10.8% ("Seasonality").

Behind the routes sits the runway. "The airport, not a shortage of visitors is what now caps Cape Town's tourism growth" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p101). One runway with no parallel taxiway caps movements at about 30 an hour, and ACSA's programme of about R11.3bn brings relief only from about 2032 (p101 to p103).

The alternatives do not close the gap in time. George, domestic only, doubles by 2028, and Cape Winelands Airport targets 2028 with no named carrier. In the Infrastructure Report's words, "the certain fix is the latest, and the earliest big-capacity option is the least certain" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p104 to p109). Route rights sit a tier up: air service agreements are a national function (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p58). The

Department of Economic Development rates restrictive bilateral agreements a high-impact constraint on airlift (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24).

Car-only regions and unbookable product

Beyond the Metro the constraint changes shape, not nature. Accessibility scores fall from 4.7 in the Cape Metro to 1.0 in the Central Karoo (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p88 to p90). Large parts of the province outside the Metro and the Garden Route remain effectively car-only destinations (p99). The further from Cape Town, the faster the infrastructure falls away (p90).

Much of what the car can reach cannot be booked. Most rural properties have no OTA presence and Route 62 has the lowest online bookability of the six touring routes (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p95, p87). Even CapeNature takes about 70% of its reservations through a call centre rather than its online platform (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p42).

Growth above the norm

Global tourism grows 3 to 5% a year under stable conditions, the band the Benchmarking Report calls organic growth (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p7). Five of the six comparator destinations grew faster over 2023 to 2024: Chile about 35%, Singapore about 19%, Kenya 12.8 to 14.6%, Valencia 13 to 14% and New Zealand about 12% on holiday arrivals (p9). Melbourne's 4.3% is an Australia-wide forecast rather than an actual (p9, p17), so the comparator range runs from about 4% to 35%.

The Western Cape's two paths straddle the band. The base case implies 3.8% a year from 2025 to 2035 and the accelerated case 5.3%, and the accelerated case reverts to base "without confirmed routes" (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19). The Benchmarking Report counts growth as structural only above that band. It must also be "driven by deliberate changes to demand drivers, access conditions or product systems, rather than cyclical recovery or short-term promotion" (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p8).

Cape Town is the axle of the system: international visitors arrive there and disperse from there, and "Cape Town remains the engine of the system, but growth cannot keep concentrating there" (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p114). The Department of Economic Development already reads the growth framing as overweight on volumes and asks for a value and spend lens in place of arrivals (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p24). Growth now needs new markets, new seasons and new regions, and each of those is a supply problem before it is a marketing problem.

1.4 Approach and method

The study ran in four phases from November 2025, tested one hypothesis tree against every interim deliverable and took each figure from a ranked hierarchy of sources.

Four phases

The Inception Report set out four phases with printed durations: inception, one month; demand-side analysis, four months; supply-side analysis, three months; enablement and final reporting, seven months (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p11). The Phase 4 detail slide prints six months for the same phase (p22); the report uses

seven, which matches the working plan from 4 May to 2 November (p23). The deliverables gantt runs November to November without printing years (p12).

Each phase had a distinct job (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p11). Inception aligned expectations and ways of working and produced the Current State Diagnostic as a literature-based baseline (p14). The demand phase covered source markets, India and China route to market, benchmarks and trends; the supply phase covered spatial readiness and community inclusion, and the two overlapped from February to April (p12, p18, p19).

The final phase built the M&E framework, consolidated the strategy into this report and prepared the launch (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p22, p23). Three mechanisms governed the work: fortnightly working sessions with Wesgro, Steering Committee sessions at milestones and fortnightly written status updates (p27). The session calendar ran from the kick-off on 13 November 2025 to a final-report Steerco pencilled for 12 June 2026 (p13).

The hypothesis tree

The analytical core is a hypothesis tree agreed in December 2025 and tested by every workstream since. The Current State Diagnostic printed it with three pillars, six themes and eighteen entries (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64). The pillars are Reshape Demand, Transform Supply and Build Enabling Capability, each carrying two themes.

The tree disciplined the evidence. The Stakeholder Insights Report mapped all 223 of its insight statements to tree entries before aggregating them (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p5, p20 to p46). The later deliverables reprinted the tree as a recap and marked the branch they addressed.

Three entries changed wording between December 2025 and March 2026 (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p7). The seasonality entry gained mega events; the institutional entry widened from Wesgro, DEDAT and CTT to local, provincial and national; the collaboration entry added public and private. No document in hand dates the change more closely than the 23 January working session and the 6 February Steerco (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p13).

The 14 October 2026 review updated the tree to twenty focus areas and gave each a disposition [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16: deck not in hand; page citation to confirm]. The three pillars and six themes stand. The Infrastructure Report of 22 September still carried the eighteen-entry tree, so the move to twenty belongs to the final review rather than to any one workstream (Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026, p2).

The entries moved in three ways; first, the air access and cruise entry split in two, because the aviation assessment and the Infrastructure Report showed them to be different problems. Second, the infrastructure, visa and safety entry moved from the supply pillar to governance, because its levers sit with national government. Third, a workforce and service skills entry was added and flagged, because the 300,000-jobs ambition has no labour analysis behind it (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4).

Six further entries were reworded to the lever the evidence supports and one was refined; the table below lists each change and the workstream behind it. Ten entries carried through as Validated with title-only edits. Chapter 3 records every disposition and section 1.5 defines the labels [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, slide 14: the deck's own change count and label definitions to confirm].

Table 1.6. Eight December entries changed scope, place or form by October 2026, one focus area was added and ten carried through as Validated.

December 2025 entry	October 2026 focus area	Change	Workstream behind it
Close the Air Access and Cruise Capacity Gaps	Win direct routes and add seats on full routes; Grow cruise calls and ports	Split; air Reworded, cruise New	MIDAS route loads and fares-before-seats finding; Infrastructure Report cruise and ports section
Lead Removal of Infrastructure, Visa and Safety Deficits	Same title, under Governance and leadership	Moved from theme 2.1 to 3.2	Stakeholder Insights, Demand-Side barriers and MIDAS place visas and air rights with national government
No December entry	Develop workforce and service skills	New; Flagged, untested	No workstream; the 300,000-jobs ambition has no labour analysis behind it
Develop the Seasonality and Spread Proposition	Create green-season demand with MICE and events	Reworded	MIDAS seasonality; Demand-Side MICE landscape
Facilitate Adoption Along the Path to Purchase	Make the whole province findable and bookable	Reworded	Inclusion Plan, Stakeholder Insights and Infrastructure Report on product that cannot be found or booked
Pivot to Growth Markets (China, India, ME, ASEAN)	Convert India and China hub traffic	Reworded	Demand-Side route to market and MIDAS hub volumes
Ensure Sustainable Destination Management	Manage climate risk and sustainable tourism	Reworded	Stakeholder Insights on LTO funding and climate losses; Inclusion Plan De Rust profile
Review Institutional Arrangements (Wesgro, DEDAT, CTT)	Align institutional stakeholders across all three tiers	Reworded	Stakeholder Insights on fragmented mandates; Diagnostic governance tiers
Drive Community and SME Inclusion	Embed local destination bodies for community inclusion	Refined	SME and Community Inclusion Plan

Source: Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64 for the December entries; dispositions as recorded at the 14 October 2026 review (Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16) [deck page reference to be confirmed].

Source hierarchy

Every figure in this report carries a source and page, and sources rank in five tiers. Where tiers disagree the higher tier wins; where two documents in one tier disagree, both values are recorded and the value used is stated with the reason. Nothing is reconciled by averaging.

1. Interim deliverables, cited by the date printed on the cover and by PDF page index, since none prints page numbers.
2. Working analyses: the Market Assessment Report of May 2026 and the three Skift memos on digital and search insights (December 2025), segmentation (March 2026) and African markets (March 2026), cited by section.
3. Wesgro and government data cited through a deliverable (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p34): the Mero 2024 reports for all six districts, the Pero 2025 and the Growth for Jobs Strategy 2023. The same tier holds the Tourism Blueprint, Wesgro's five-year strategy and the StratEcon cruise liner economic contribution studies for 2023, 2024 and 2024/25.
4. Benchmark and reference reports, such as the UN Tourism barometer behind the global growth norm (Global Benchmarking Report, Mar 2026, p7).
5. External public sources, used only where no higher tier carries the figure and labelled as such.

Two conventions follow. The MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment and the Skift memos are Word files without page numbers, so they are cited by section title. The 14 October 2026 summary deck ranks below the deliverables: where the two differ, the deliverable's figure is used and the difference is logged.

The reconciliation behind this rule logged 55 discrepancies between the agreed structure and the deliverables, seven of them material. They concern the model base year, the October to March share, the routes above 80% load, the comparator growth range, the 2035 ambition, the cruise call baseline and the Infrastructure Report's date. Each is resolved where it is used, with both values shown.

Interim deliverables

Nine dated documents carry the evidence, and the table below dates each by its cover. Three carry a later file date than their cover, which the report records rather than hides. The Market Assessment Report of May 2026 is the working analysis behind the Demand-Side Analysis and alone prints the 2025 base the growth case uses (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19).

Table 1.7. Nine dated documents carry the evidence and answer the SLA clauses the final report consolidates.

Document	Cover date	Version in hand	SLA clauses answered	Summarised in
Inception Report	Nov 2025	37 slides; working session of 28 November 2025; no tree printed	[to confirm against Annexure B]	1.1, 1.4
Current State Diagnostic	Dec 2025	v2 in the file name; December tree on p64	[to confirm against Annexure B]	1.2; folded into 2.1 and 2.5
Stakeholder Insights Report (phase 1)	Mar 2026	File dated 12 March 2026; sixteen organisation tables	1.1.6, 3.2.8	2.4
Global Benchmarking Report	Mar 2026	Cover prints 2026 only; file dated 24 March 2026	1.1.5, 1.1.11, 3.2.7	2.3
MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment	Mar 2026	Word file marked final draft, dated 20 April 2026; no page numbers	1.1.1.2	2.2
Market Assessment Report	May 2026	Working analysis; predecessor of the Demand-Side Analysis; prints the 2025 model base	Working analysis under 1.1.1 [to confirm]	2.1
Demand-Side Analysis	Jun 2026	Final; file dated 1 October 2026	1.1.1, 1.1.7, 3.2.3	2.1
Infrastructure Report	Jul 2026	Final of 114 slides, file dated 22 September 2026; June 2026 draft of 42 slides superseded	1.1.2, 1.1.8, 3.2.4	2.5
SME and Community Inclusion Plan	Sep 2026	File dated 9 October 2026	1.1.3, 1.1.9, 3.2.5	2.6

Source: Cover pages and file dates of each document; SLA Annexure B clause numbers as assigned in the agreed report structure of 2 November 2026 [to be checked against the signed Annexure B].

Stakeholder engagement

Stakeholder engagement ran in four phases alongside the analysis (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p4, p17). Introduction and framing ran from January to March 2026, sense-making and validation in April and May, strategy socialisation in June and July and mobilisation from August into October. The Stakeholder Insights Report closed the first phase with insight tables for sixteen organisations, from Mossel Bay to the CTICC (p20 to p46). Sixteen is a count of those tables; the report prints no tally.

The method was strict about what an insight is. Sessions were run, insights extracted, each mapped to a tree entry and then aggregated (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p5). The 223 statements are the project team's paraphrases rated High, Medium or Low, not quotations, so this report attributes them to organisations and never to named individuals (p5, p20 to p46).

Two gaps in the record matter: phase 1 engaged no airline, online travel agent or tour operator, and the six demand-side engagements were proposed for phase 2 (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p16). The demand work drew instead on discussions with more than 20 stakeholders of its own (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p7). The outcomes of engagement phases 2 to 4 sit in no document in hand [Letsema to supply the phase 2 to 4 engagement record for Appendix A6].

Data limits

Five limits in the data shape how the findings read. The headline arrivals series counts international passenger arrivals at Cape Town International, not tourists, and Cape Town air arrivals stand proxy for the province in the market shares (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25, p26, p29). No approved methodology exists for provincial tourism GDP and jobs, and no deliverable prints a Western Cape tourism employment baseline (Stakeholder Insights Report, Mar 2026, p37).

The supply dataset carries no geography below district, and the records added after May 2026 to extend its coverage are placeholders rather than surveyed assets [Infrastructure Report, Jul 2026: page reference for the dataset notes to confirm]. The inclusion analysis runs on an OpenStreetMap asset layer, extracted on 16 September 2026, joined to Census 2011 sub-places, so its resident shares are fifteen years old (SME and Community Inclusion Plan, Sep 2026, p14 to p17).

The growth model exists in two editions. The May Market Assessment runs from a 2025 base of 1,498,829 arrivals and the June Demand-Side Analysis from a 2024 base of 1,445,031 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19; Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p20). Both reach 2,175,778 in the base case and 2,516,282 in the accelerated case by 2035. The report runs the growth case from the 2025 base, keeps FY24/25's 1.44m as the recovery baseline and states which is which wherever both appear.

Completion plan

A six-week completion plan agreed on 12 October 2026 governs the last stage of the work. [Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026: six-week plan from 12 October, with weekly outputs and owners, to be inserted; deck not in hand.] It replaces the inception timetable, which placed report consolidation between 1 June and 27 July 2026 and launch support to 2 November (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p23). The report goes to Steerco, Exco and the Board before the public launch in February 2027.

1.5 How to read this report

The report is built so that a Board member can read the summary and any one focus area on its own, and a programme owner can run the plan from Chapters 3 to 5.

Chapter map

The report moves from context to evidence to recommendations to delivery, and the table below gives the route through it for each reader.

Table 1.8. Seven parts carry the report from the case in short to the evidence behind every figure, and each part has a primary reader.

Part	What it answers	Who should read it
Executive summary	The case in short: the growth case to 2035, the constraints that cap it, the twenty focus areas by pillar, the first 24 months and the headline indicators	Board, Exco and the February 2027 launch audience; it stands alone
1 Context	What Wesgro asked for, where the system stands after recovery, why the next step is supply-constrained and how the study ran	Every reader; the Board member who reads no other chapter of the body
2 Analysis summaries	What each interim deliverable asked, did and found, with the evidence that survived into the hypothesis tree	Readers checking the evidence behind a Chapter 3 entry; each section closes with a box naming the focus areas it supports
3 Findings and recommendations	For each of the twenty focus areas: the December hypothesis, its disposition, the evidence, what Wesgro does, what it asks of partners and what it escalates nationally	Board and Exco by entry; the programme owner in full; Section 3.4 for the sequence
4 Execution plan	Which initiatives, in what order, owned by whom, at what cost and with which decision gates	The programme owner, Steerco and the partners named in the RACI
5 Monitoring and evaluation	How progress is measured: indicators, baselines, targets, data sources, the scorecard and the 2030 mid-term review	Wesgro Research, the programme office and Steerco
Appendices A1 to A9	The traceability table, the demand model, the benchmark cases, readiness scores, the community fact base, stakeholder inputs, charters, the toolkit and references	Analysts and anyone checking a figure

Source: Letsema, structure of this report, November 2026.

Disposition labels

Each Chapter 3 entry records what the study believed in December 2025 and what the evidence did to that belief. The December tree held eighteen entries under three pillars and six themes (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p64); the tree settled at the 14 October 2026 review keeps the pillars and themes and holds twenty focus areas.

Table 1.9. Six labels record what the evidence did to each December hypothesis, and ten of the twenty focus areas carry Validated.

Label	Meaning	Focus areas
Validated	The evidence confirmed the December hypothesis as written	10
Refined	The evidence confirmed the hypothesis and sharpened its content	1
Reworded	The evidence confirmed the hypothesis; the entry was renamed to what the evidence showed	6
New	Added in October 2026, with no December entry behind it	1
Withdrawn	Dropped because the evidence did not support the hypothesis	0
Flagged	Untested; carried as a question for analysis still to be commissioned	1

Source: Dispositions as recorded at the 14 October 2026 review (Summary of Findings, 14 Oct 2026, pp15 to 16) [deck page reference to be confirmed against the final deck]; counts from the traceability table in Appendix A1.

One focus area carries a note rather than a label, so the counts sum to nineteen. Lead removal of infrastructure, visa and safety deficits keeps its December wording but moves from supply theme 2.1 to governance theme 3.2, because its levers sit nationally. [Summary of Findings deck, 14 Oct 2026, to confirm the label for the moved entry and that nothing was Withdrawn]

Citations and figures

Every figure carries its source and page in the form (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p21). The date is the cover date and the page is the PDF page index counted from the cover, because none of the decks prints page numbers. The MIDAS Aviation Market Assessment and the three Skift memos have no fixed pagination and are cited by section title.

Three cover dates differ from their file dates. The Demand-Side Analysis is cited as June 2026 though its file is dated 1 October 2026 and the Inclusion Plan cites a 16 September version. The Infrastructure Report cited is the July 2026 final, not the June draft; the SME and Community Inclusion Plan prints September 2026 on a file dated 9 October.

Where two inputs disagree the report states the value it uses, names the other with its page and gives the reason. The five-market share, printed as both 63% and 61% on one slide, is one case (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p13). Nothing is averaged and nothing is reconciled silently.

Two arrivals figures recur and measure different things. The recovery baseline is 1.44m international passenger arrivals at Cape Town International in FY24/25, ACSA's fiscal-year count (Current State Diagnostic, Dec 2025, p25). The growth model runs from 1,498,829 arrivals in 2025 (Market Assessment Report, May 2026, p19) to 2,175,778 in the base case and 2,516,282 in the accelerated case in 2035 (Demand-Side Analysis, Jun 2026, p20).

The strategy's 2.5m is the accelerated case rounded. The word doubling appears only where the report quotes the original mandate (Inception Report, Nov 2025, p4).

Marks and codes

Highlighted text in square brackets marks an open item: a figure no input in hand carries, with the figure needed and who holds it. Every page of this draft carries DRAFT FOR DISCUSSION in its header and the cover carries a draft line; both come off at sign-off.

Three codes tie the chapters together. A Chapter 3 kicker names the entry's theme, 1.1 to 3.2, above the focus area name as it reads on the tree; each entry closes with the initiative and indicator it links to. Initiatives in Chapter 4 run I1 onwards in one sequence; indicators in Chapter 5 run T1-01 onwards for impact, T2-01 for outcome and T3-01 for output.

Appendix A1 holds the traceability table. For each focus area it records the pillar, theme, disposition and one-line reason, the December entry it descends from, the workstream behind the disposition and its initiative and indicator codes. Any Chapter 3 claim can be followed back to a page and forward to an owner and a measure.

Analysis summaries

Findings and recommendations

Execution plan

Monitoring and evaluation framework

Appendices